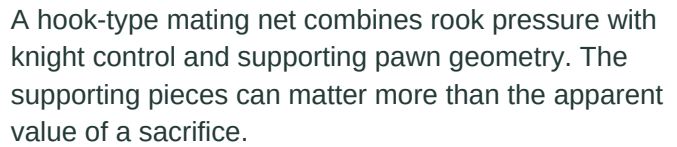


Hook mating nets

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Identify the final checking line and then trace which friendly pieces protect the attacker and control the king's exits.

The defending king is on d6. Geometrically undefended: rook on b8 and bishop on g7. Check for tactical protection.

Previous move: 25...Kd6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

26. Nf7+ Kc6 27. Rc7#

26.Nf7+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **26...Kc6**.

27.Rc7# Mate: rook on c7 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on c6. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on c7. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

Recount the king's legal replies after each move. A changed pawn placement can destroy an otherwise familiar mating pattern.